

Instructure.

Instructure Life Changing Education

SI 500 – 011

Team 2

Professor: Tawanna Dillahunt



The team:



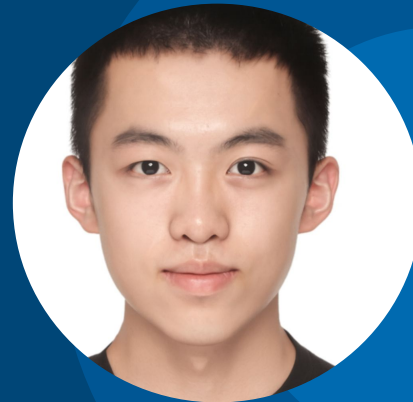
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UX Research and Design



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Big Data Analysis

AGENDA

MOTIVATION

ANALYSIS

RECOMMENDATIONS

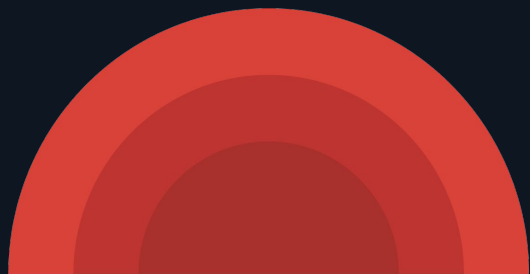
Q & A

MOTIVATION

Section 1



Client Introduction



**Teaching
and learning**



**Assessment
and growth**



**Credentials
and opportunity**

Complex Problem: Will Alternative Pathways Impact Societal Knowledge?

PROBLEM STATEMENT

Currently, the proportion of people who do not attend traditional universities, in US

79%

This validates the urgency of **improving non-traditional learning platforms** to serve the dominant learning space.

Source: Forbes – Nietzel (2025)

How many people are in alternative pathway

61%

This highlights a critical opportunity to **strengthen and legitimize alternative education** through better-designed platforms.

Source: National Student Clearinghouse Research Center (2025)

What proportion of people are negatively impacted by the lack of a reliable learning platform

29%

Addressing this requires platforms that are **structured, validated, and responsive to learner needs.**

Source: Forbes – Nietzel (2025)

How Might We

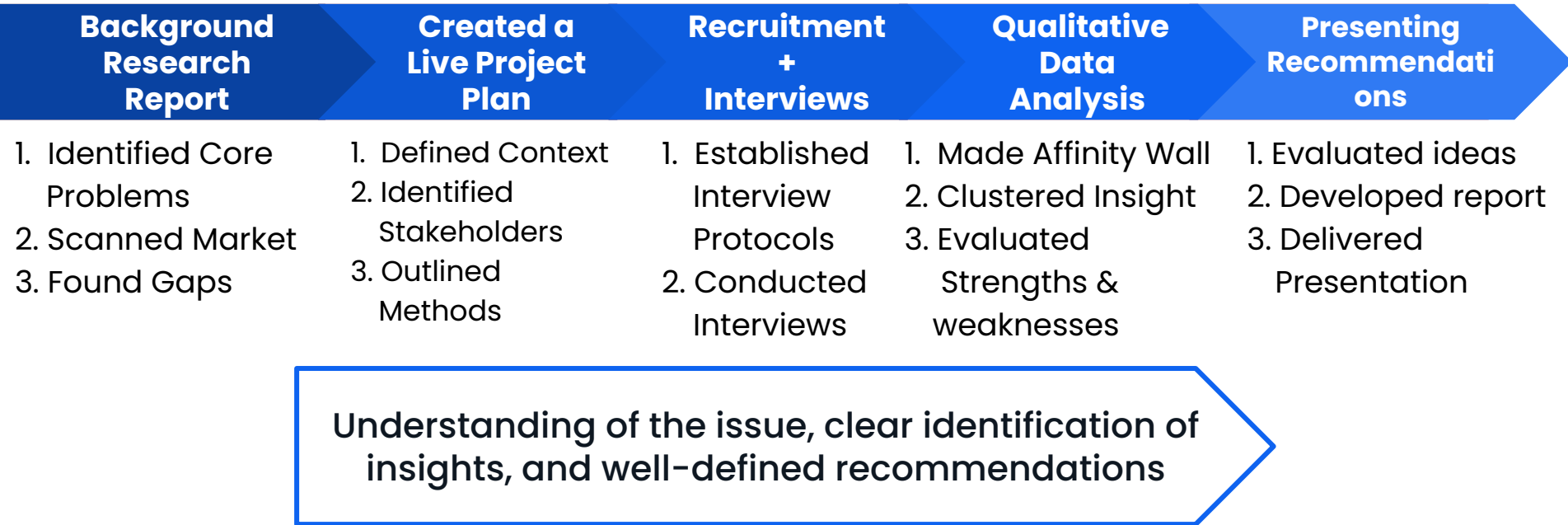
How might Instructure refine its **current products or develop a new product to include individuals on alternative pathways into its educational ecosystem**, empowering them by **strengthening lifelong learning and employability**, therefore ensuring Instructure's **long-term competitiveness** in the future EdTech Industry.

ANALYSIS

Section 2



Research Process



Research Findings

01	Structural Incompatibility	<i>"I don't have hours to study. I need effective fragmented learning"</i>
02	Need-Driven Engagement	<i>"I learn because I need the skill"</i>
03	Mid-Journey Disorientation	<i>"I often feel lost in the middle. I'm not sure where I stand in my progress or exactly what step I should take next."</i>
04	The Employability Gap	<i>"I've finished the lessons, but will this effort actually help me land a job?"</i>
05	Soft Skill Barrier	<i>"The cultivation of soft skills has been neglected in the alternative education pathway "</i>

Primary Persona



Lauren Case

Age: 29

Pathway: Alternative, formal school early, pursued work + self-learning

Hometown: Southfield, MI

Education: Participates in short-term online bootcamps.

Occupation: Operations coordinator at a small company

"I'm done with scattered learning. I want a clear path that actually makes me employable without a formal degree"

Pain Points

- **Limited time in studying**
- **Lack guidance** in learning skills
- **Soft-skill gaps** aren't addressed by bootcamps.
- **Scattered learning**
- **Limited access** to knowledgeable mentors.
- Difficulty **translating hustle into employable competencies**.

Motivations

- Driven by embarrassment she once felt working with **more educated colleagues**.
- Wants **fair access** to jobs without needing a degree.
- Desires a sense of **competence and systematic thinking** in her work.
- Believes deeply in **constant learning** and wants **guidance**, not random self-learning.

Goals

- Build **structured knowledge** rather than fragmented learning.
- Gain **practical soft skills** (communication, teamwork, logic, problem-solving).
- Become more **"officially qualified"** through meaningful micro-credentials.
- Access a pathway that connects learning to **real employability**.

RECOMMENDATIONS

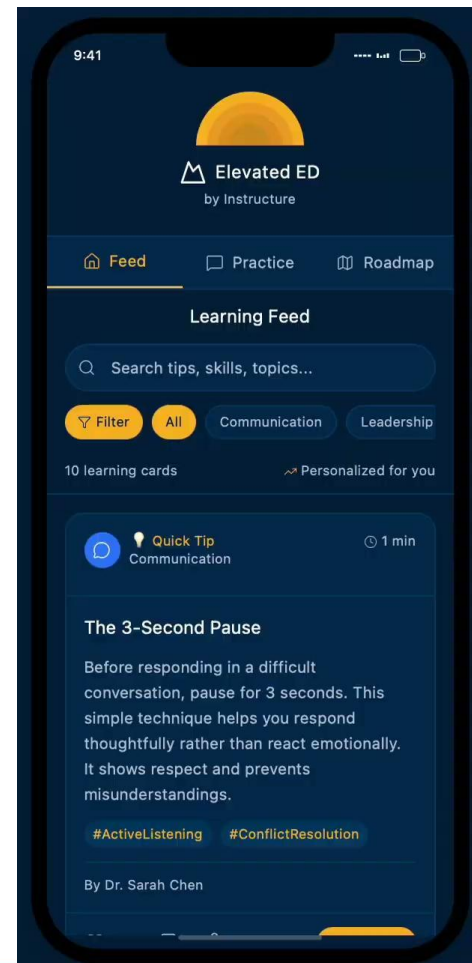
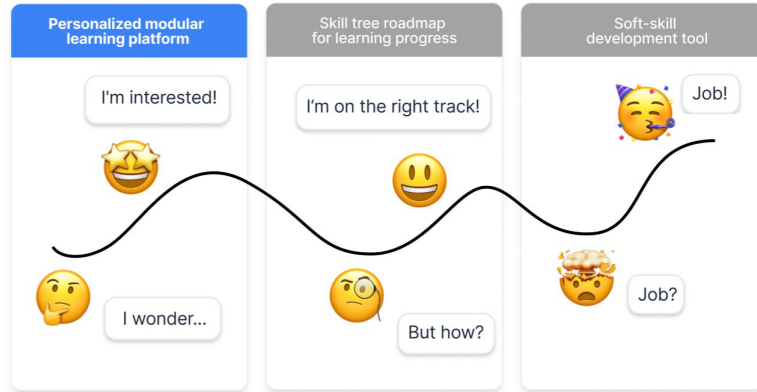
Section 3



Recommendation 1:

Personalized modular learning platform

- **A feed** based on **search** and **recommendations**
- **Small chunks** of learning materials
- Supports **unplanned** or **curiosity-based learning behaviors**, giving users a **low-pressure, flexible** starting point to learn something new.

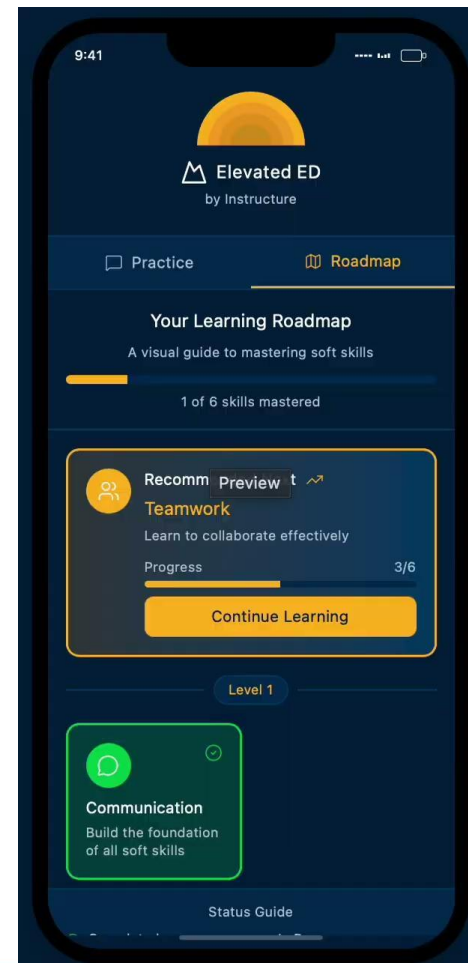
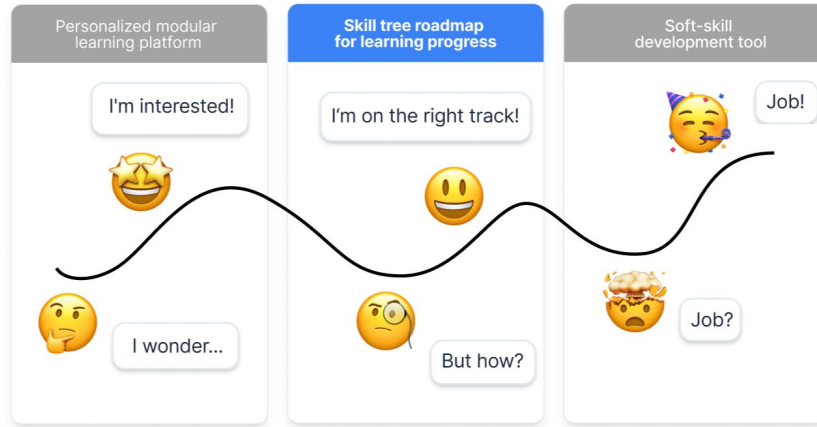


Target
Pain Point

Lack of
Time

Recommendation 2: Skill tree roadmap for learning progress

- A **tree-structured learning roadmapping** tool that **visualizes** users' **learning progress** and provides **clear guidance** of the **learning process**.
- Helps learners clarify the **direction or scope** of learning

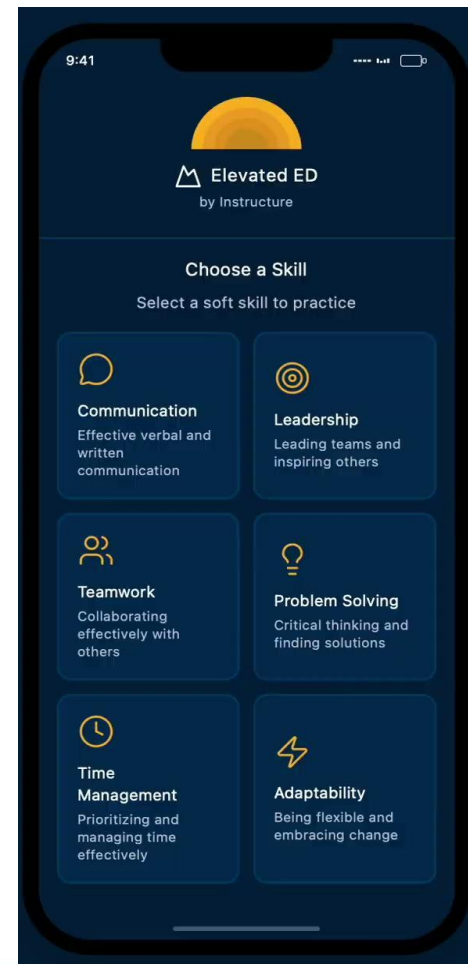
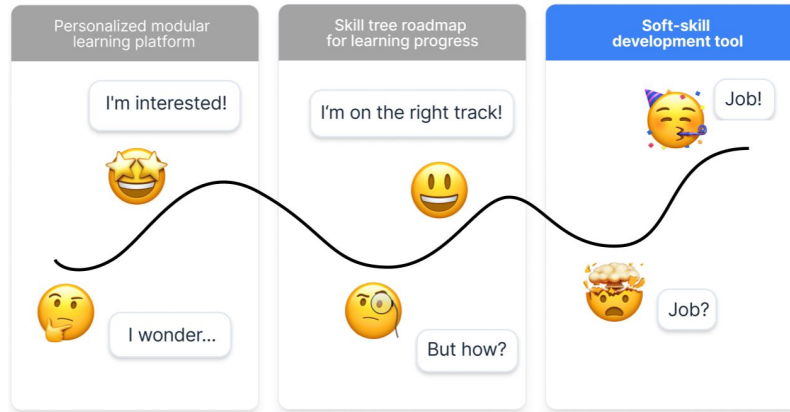


Target
Pain Point

Lack of
Guidance

Recommendation 3: Soft-skill development tool

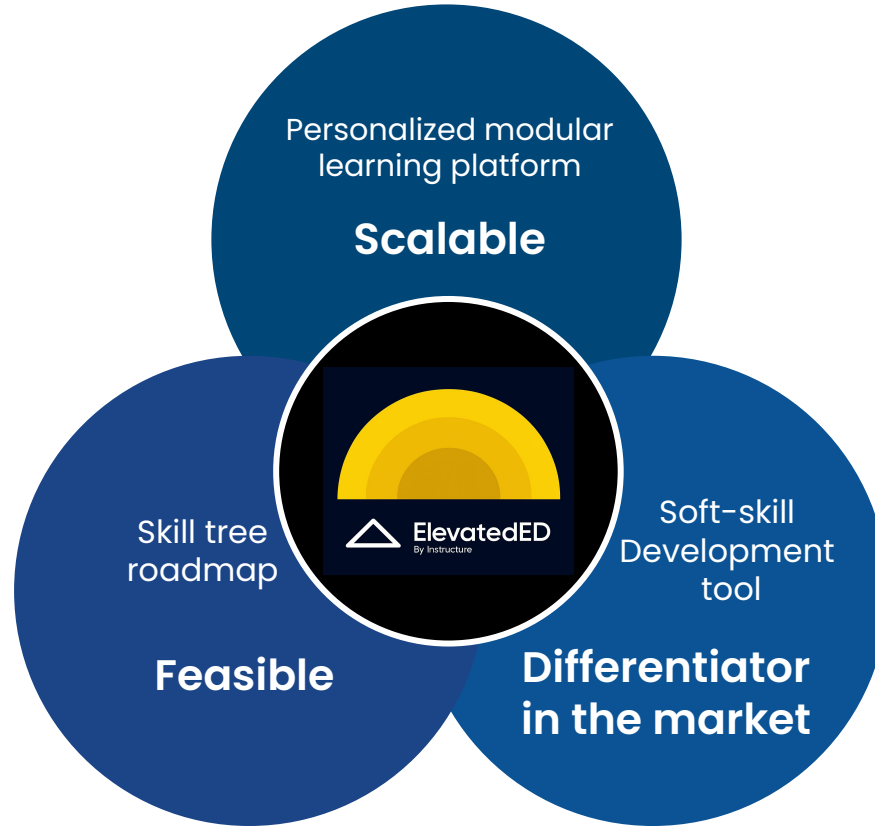
- AI chatbot, acts like **an interviewer**
- Encourages users to **reflect on their learning experience** and how to articulate it in interviews
- **Enhances users' employability** through the review, evaluation, and practice of soft skills.



**Target
Pain Point**

**Lack of
evaluation &
practice
of soft skills**

Conclusion



Q & A

Section 4

Special thanks to our client Instructure, our Professor Tawanna R. Dillahunt, our TA Cari Jacobs, our Interview Participants, our SI500 classmates, and all our audiences!



ElevatedED
By Instructure

Key Takeaways

1

Problem:
Alternative-pathway learners
lack time, guidance and
soft-skill support

2

Needs: A flexible, guided, and
employability-focused
learning ecosystem

3

Our Solution: ElevatedED
integrates three functions to
address these needs

Appendix Map

[References/Acknowledgements](#)

[Recommendations Analysis: Pugh Matrix](#)

[Instructure Information](#)

[Live Project Plan](#)

[Detailed Research Process](#)

[Background Research Report](#)

[Research Method: Interviews](#)

[Secondary Persona](#)

[Qualitative Data Analysis: Affinity Diagram](#)

References

The slide design is inspired by Instructure's *State of Learning and Readiness* report.

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Recommendations Analysis: Pugh Matrix

Selection Criteria	Personalized modular learning platform	Skill tree roadmap for learning progress	Softskill development tools
Alignment with Instructures' Strategy (*2)	4	2	5
Voice of Customer (*1.5)	5	4	3
Voice of the Business (*1.5)	5	2	5
Scalability	5	3	5
Accessibility	5	2	2
Total	33	18	29

Scoring Baseline	
5	Strong alignment
4	Good alignment
3	Somewhat aligned
2	Don't know
1	No alignment

Instructure.

K-12

4,390+ institutions



Springfield Public Schools
A culture of equity and excellence



- ✓ **51%** of top 250 US K-12 districts use Canvas
- ✓ **11** State-wide deployments during COVID⁴
- ✓ **1,200+** Schools in Queensland, Australia
- ✓ Many of the largest K-12 Systems in the US

Higher Education

2,540+ institutions



- ✓ **50%** of college and university students in the US and Canada
- ✓ All Top Ten Universities in the US
- ✓ All Ivy League Universities
- ✓ **83%** of US research universities
- ✓ **116** California Community Colleges
- ✓ Higher Education systems for Sweden & Norway

Non-traditional

1,270+ institutions



- ✓ **400+** Higher Education institutions cross-sold with Non-traditional solutions
- ✓ **1,270+** Professional learning customers
- ✓ **~4M** Non-traditional contracted users

Live Project Plan

01	Summarized Background Context	- Analyzed social norms that influence learner behaviors - Performing targeted market research
02	Stakeholders Identified:	- HR professionals - Alternative Pathway students who did not attend college or attend later in life - Our client partners from different business units
03	Research Method/ Interview Protocol	- Qualitative Research: Interviews - Analyzed the Data through Affinity Diagram
04	Project Details/Roles/Timeline	- Served as the Lead Researcher for the project - Collaborated with the team for 3 hours weekly - Coordinated primarily through Slack and Zoom
05	Project Outputs	- Shared three high-impact recommendations with the client - Showcased a prototype and new visual identity for the system

Detailed Research Process

Background Research Report	Created a Live Project Plan	Recruitment + Interviews	Qualitative Data Analysis	Presenting Recommendations
1. Identify the Core Problem 2. Gather Market Data About Instructure 3. Analyze Societal Shifts in Learning Pathways 4. Benchmark Against Competitors 5. Identify Gaps in Instructure's Ecosystem	1. Summarized Background Context 2. Stakeholders Identified: 3. Research Method 4. Set roles and project norms 5. Project Outputs	1. Recruitment Strategy 2. Selected Participants 3. Developed an Interview Protocol Document 4. Conducted and recorded the interviews	1. Created an Affinity Diagram 2. Key Insight Clusters Identified 3. Strengths & Weaknesses Noted by Consultant	1. Pugh Matrix to Access the recommendations 2. Developed a recommendation report 3. Presented the recommendations to our consultant 4. Presented to the strategy team and 180+ people

Background Research Report

Client Insight → Market Insight → Societal Insight → Competitor Insight → Opportunity Insight

1. Client Insight
 - Conducted informational interview with Instructure's partner
2. Market Insight
 - Performed detailed competitor landscape review
3. Societal Insight
 - Analyzed shifting learning pathways and credential trends
4. Competitor Insight
 - Benchmarked Instructure against top LMS competitors
5. Opportunity Insight
 - Identified critical gaps and opportunities in Instructure's ecosystem

Research Method: Interviews

Recruitment → Interview Protocol → Interviews Conducted

Recruitment/ Interview Insight

- Recruited HR professionals through professional networks
- Recruited alternative-pathway learners through business community groups
- Included Instructure partner to provide strategic product insight
- Conducted 10 total interviews across all stakeholder groups

Interview Protocol Insight

Semi-structured script and questions covering:

- Role & background
- Learning journey & barriers
- Hiring experiences & soft-skill needs
- Credential credibility & skill verification-Opportunities for improved pathways

Document tabs

Final interview protocols ...

Summary:

Protocols

Introduction script

Stakeholder Group #1:

Stakeholder Group #2

Stakeholder Group #3

Interviewee List

Completed Interviews

Planned Interviews

Interview Analytical Mem...

Wentao He Memo

Xingyue Wang Memo

Name: Xingyue Wang

Ping Yin Memo

Layilah Nasser Memo

Stakeholder Group #2

Instructure

- **Overarching question:**
What is Instructure's long-term strategy for evolving its current systems, and what plans does Instructure have to include people who choose alternative pathways into its education ecosystem?
- **Stakeholder description:**
We plan to interview Melissa. She is the Chief Academic Officer at Instructure. We aim to collect qualitative data on Instructure's strategic vision, product ecosystem, and its approach to supporting learners on alternative pathways. The interview is expected to last about 20 minutes.
- **Key questions:**
 1. Could you briefly describe your role at Instructure and how your research connects with the product strategy of Instructure?
 2. What is Instructure's definition of "student in alternative pathways" or "non-traditional student"?
 3. How do you think the needs of an alternative student or nontraditional student differ from those of traditional students?
 4. How well do Instructure's current products support alternative pathway learners, and where do you see the most significant gaps?
 5. From a strategy perspective, what opportunities or risks do you see in expanding

7

Appendix: Secondary Persona:

"We look for teamwork, adaptability, communication — the soft skills that set people apart."



Andrea Smith

Age: 34

Pathway: Traditional, Formal Schooling

Hometown: Charlestown, SC

Education: Masters in HR from Penn

Occupation: Corporate HR Specialist, 8+ years in hiring, screening, and evaluating talent

Pain Points

- Verification difficulty
- Resume filters
- Inconsistency
- Lack of translation
- Candidate articulation:

Motivations

- Wants candidates who demonstrate *ownership, reliability, professionalism, and teamwork*.
- Believes that interpersonal and soft skills often matter more than a degree.
- Appreciates clear, specific examples of applied skills (metrics, achievements, leadership moments).
- Values certifications only if they're issued by trusted, recognizable organizations.

Goals

- Hire candidates who can perform consistently, work well in fast-paced environments, and uphold service standards.
- Reduce risk by ensuring candidates' skills are valid, verifiable, and aligned with actual job requirements.
- Streamline hiring by filtering large applicant pools efficiently.
- Improve clarity in resumes so she can quickly gauge qualifications.
- Build a fairer process that does not unintentionally filter out strong nontraditional candidates.

Qualitative Data Analysis: Affinity Diagram

